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MINI PLENARY - NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

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PROCEEDINGS OF MINI-PLENARY SESSION OF THE NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Members of the mini-plenary session met at Committee Room M46 at 16:45.

The House Chairperson, Mr W Horn, took the Chair and requested members to observe a moment of silence for prayer or meditation.

APPROPRIATION BILL

Debate on Vote No 42 - Land Reform and Rural Development:

The MINISTER OF LAND REFORM AND RURAL DEVELOPMENT: House Chairperson, Deputy Minister hon Mathabatha, hon members, my Chief Whip, Gana, chairperson and members of the Portfolio Committee on Land Reform and Rural Development, government officials, I greet you.

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It is a distinct honour to present Budget Vote 42 of the Department of Land Reform and Rural Development for the 2026-27 financial year. We are presenting this Budget Vote at a time when the aspirations and hopes of the majority of our people in these two broad areas have been heightened as the result of a range of commitments that we continue to make as well as several positive impacts that are being realized at the level of implementation. In this address we thus focus not only on the financial resource part of our work, but also on what we are doing in the sphere of developing the necessary policy and legislative frameworks.

The work of the department remains directed towards advancing the constitutional and legislative mandates entrusted to it on equitable access to land, restitution of land rights, ensuring tenure security, supporting sustainable rural livelihoods and promoting rural prosperity, modernising land administration systems, and improving spatial governance across all spheres of government.

These responsibilities remain central to addressing the historical legacies of dispossession, poverty, inequality, exclusion, underdevelopment and uneven spatial development. It

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is a generally accepted fact that land reform requires co-ordinated implementation across government. In this regard, as it discharges its mandate, our department continues to work within the Inter-Ministerial Committee on Land Reform and Agriculture, which is chaired by the Deputy President.

This institutional mechanism assists in improving co-ordination across departments, reducing duplication, strengthening implementation oversight, and supporting integrated planning in relation to land reform and agricultural development. During the reporting period, the department acquired approximately 53 000 hectares of land and allocated more than 35 000 hectares to qualifying individuals and communities. In line with the Cabinet-approved Beneficiary Selection and Land Allocation Policy, approximately 20 000 hectares of land were allocated to women and 13 000 hectares to youth beneficiaries.

While this is a positive development, we recognise the need to improve further in this regard. The department will thus continue to prioritise equitable access to land for women, youth, persons with disabilities, and other qualifying beneficiaries. In our pursuit of strengthening tenure

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security, approximately 7000 hectares were acquired and transferred to more than 700 farm dwellers and labour tenants.

With the support of the Special Master on Labour Tenants, 61 labour tenant matters were finalised, while 313 matters were referred to court where negotiations with landowners could not be concluded successfully. Additionally, approximately 206 000 hectares of land were transferred from the state to affected communities through the implementation of the Transformation of Certain Rural Areas Act, 94 of 1998.

At the strategic policy and legislative levels, we have identified the need to conduct a comprehensive land audit, to amend the Beneficiary Selection and Allocation Policy for beneficiaries of the Proactive Land Acquisition Strategy, PLAS, and to develop the necessary policies and legislation to give effect to the constitutional mandates on equitable access to land, communal land tenure and administration, rural development, and land administration.

We have also identified the rationalisation of apartheid laws as a long-standing factor that continues to complicate the work of the department in discharging its land reform mandate,

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as many such laws that still exist on the statute book are in direct conflict with the Constitution. This work is to be conducted under the auspices of a retired judge whose appointment process is underway.

As an essential instrument for planning purposes, one of the key objectives of the comprehensive land audit is to resolve the ongoing lack of clarity and disputes around the amount of land that is in the possession of the state. This also applies to communal land, especially with regard to the question of how much movement has occurred in shifting from the 13% that was originally accessible to Africans during the apartheid period, including land that has changed hands through market mechanisms. Most importantly, the comprehensive land audit will also bring certainty about who owns what land in South Africa, in terms of race, gender, business entity, land held in trusts, regional distribution, as well as nationality.

With regard to ensuring equitable access to land, we have reviewed and amended the existing Beneficiary Selection and Allocation Policy in such a way as to ensure that it provides adequately for those who lack the financial and educational requirements that were previously insisted upon. Yet such

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individuals consistently and without fail demonstrate the potential to operate successfully as farmers while working under severely constrained conditions of land shortage and infrastructure deficits in communal areas.

Similarly, we have strengthened the provisions that relate to military veterans and former political prisoners. The Equitable Access to Land Bill, which is aimed at giving effect to the provisions of section 25(5) of the Constitution, will serve as the centrepiece of the implementation of the Redistribution Programme.

In this regard, we have made provision for the establishment of a Land Reform Agency as a cutting-edge service delivery institution whose responsibilities will focus on land and beneficiary identification, allocation, and post-settlement support. This Bill, which we have reported on during previous occasions, is at the stage where it is being prepared to be presented to Cabinet and thereafter for public consultation by June this year.

The process of developing the Communal Land Tenure and Administration Bill, which is aimed at giving effect to the

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provisions of section 25(6) of the Constitution, is also on course to be presented to Cabinet and to be taken through the public consultation process by the end of June this year.

This Bill seeks to address not only the constitutionally mandated function of ensuring legally secure tenure for the millions of residents of the former homelands and other communal areas. It also seeks to introduce a sustainable, democratic, gender and youth empowering system of communal land administration in which communities and traditional leaders will work together in a mutually supportive manner. The department is working according to a timeline that will result in both Bills being taken through the necessary parliamentary processes by the middle of next year.

The process of resolving the current impasse around the Ingonyama Trust Board - which the media has reported upon substantially - is being expedited. Similarly, we welcome the letter from the Speaker of the House urging us to address concerns raised by traditional leaders and the Ingonyama Trust.

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The governance and functionality of Communal Property Associations, CPAs, remains a significant area of departmental concern and focus because of continuing challenges that are facing many of these institutions. The instability also assumes the form of serious tensions between communities and traditional leaders, which is a phenomenon that we are committed to address through effective governance systems and sustainable institutional arrangements. The Communal Land Tenure and Administration Bill will also go a long way towards achieving this objective.

The department had planned to train 790 CPA executive members during the reporting period and exceeded this target by training 821 executives in governance, financial management, land administration, and institutional management-related matters. Ministerial CPA roadshows were conducted across all nine provinces and involved engagement with 507 CPAs and approximately 2465 members. These engagements consistently raised concerns relating to governance instability, internal disputes, business unsustainability, inadequate or no post-settlement support, lack of proper accountability systems, and as already mentioned, poor relationships between CPAs and traditional institutions. Also as indicated on previous

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occasions, we remain committed to holding a national CPA Indaba during the course of this year.

The work that we have been doing on CPAs is closely linked to efforts that we have made during the reporting period with regard to transferring land and issuing title deeds to communities in many parts of the country. Over the medium-term, the department's budget amounts to approximately R32,1 billion, with an allocation of R10,336 billion for the 2026-27 financial year. The department has budgeted R630 million for the 2026-27 financial year for the acquisition and allocation of approximately 57 751 hectares of land for redistribution and tenure-related purposes.

The department will further support 60 farms through the Land Development Support programme while continuing to strengthen production support and rural infrastructure interventions. An amount of approximately R388 million has been allocated for infrastructure and production support linked to these interventions.

The Restitution Programme remains central to addressing land dispossession arising from racially discriminatory laws and

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practices that were implemented after 19 June 1913. As at 31 December 2025, a total of 83 721 land claims had been settled through the programme. These settlements benefited approximately 2 396 613 individual beneficiaries and 468 761 households. Of these, 181 411 were female-headed and 1 291 were households headed by persons living with disabilities.

In its totality since its inception in 1995, the Restitution Programme has seen the restoration of approximately 3 916 733 hectares of land to beneficiaries at the cost of approximately R27 billion. In addition, approximately R27,6 billion has been paid as financial compensation to qualifying beneficiaries, while approximately R5,5 billion has been allocated in the form of development grants in terms of section 42C of the Restitution of Land Rights Act, 22 of 1994 – as amended.

For the 2026-27 financial year, the Commission on Restitution of Land Rights plans to settle 307 claims and finalise 284.

The number of outstanding old order land claims currently stands at 5 245. It is important to also mention that my ministry has now begun the process of working towards complying with the court injunctions relating to new order land claims, which are those that were lodged when the window

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for lodgement was reopened between 2014 and 2016. This will entail working with the department draft and to introduce legislation to this hon House, so that we open 2014 new order claims.

The commission has been allocated approximately R3,839 billion for the current financial year. This allocation supports compensation of employees, operational requirements, transfers to households, and capital expenditure necessary for restitution implementation.

The Deputy Minister, Comrade Stan Mathabatha, will provide a more expansive input on the rural development functional area, covering the various relevant policies, plans and programmes. Suffice it for me to say that this area is critical to addressing the longstanding phenomenon of rural underdevelopment and the need to transform households and communities in these areas to a level of vibrancy, sustainability, and prosperity.

The land administration function is central to property rights, investment certainty, land development, and integrated public administration. As one of the key functions in this

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area, deeds registration continues to provide legal certainty in relation to registered rights in land and property, and it supports housing delivery, municipal administration, infrastructure investment, and broader economic activity.

During the 2026-27 financial year, the department will continue advancing the implementation of the Electronic Deeds Registration System, eDRS, as part of broader efforts to modernise land registration systems ...

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Hon Minister, the 15 minutes you asked for at the beginning has expired. You have five minutes towards the end, but if you continue now obviously the five minutes will shrink.

The MINISTER OF LAND REFORM AND RURAL DEVELOPMENT: You promised me 20 minutes.

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Yes, 15 plus five is 20.

The MINISTER OF LAND REFORM AND RURAL DEVELOPMENT: Okay. The National Geomatics Management Services, NGMS, function remains essential to land administration, infrastructure development,

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geospatial co-ordination, investment certainty, and spatial planning. The department will thus continue to strengthen cadastral survey processing and maintaining the integrity of land parcel information required for orderly development and secure property registration.

A significant development, which also underscores our country's growing international footprint, is that the 28th International Federation of Surveyors Congress 2026 and General Assembly is to be held in Cape Town from 24 to 29 May 2026. This is the largest such event in the world, which attracts around 1 200 to 1 500 experts in land surveying, geospatial sciences, spatial planning and construction management.

Hon House Chair, let me stop here ...

IsiXhosa:

... ukuze imizuzu yam emine eshiyekileyo ndingade ngayo uMngxitam noMatiase.

English:

Thank you very much, House Chair.

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Mr M MRARA: Hon House Chairperson, the Minister and the Deputy Ministers, hon members, the officials led by the director-general of the department, I rise today on behalf of the ANC to articulate our support for a transformative vision for our rural heartland. It is a vision where spatial justice, technological innovation and infrastructural development converge to dismantle the longstanding and enduring legacy of colonialism and apartheid. The ANC remains unyielding in its commitment to rural transformation and refuses to treat rural development as an isolated policy block. Instead, we declare it the foundational catalyst of our nationwide economic growth.

Through aggressive execution of the Infrastructure Development in Rural Areas Policy and our Integrated Rural Development Sector Strategy, we are matching land restoration with intensive post-settlement support. To contribute to inclusive economic growth and job creation, government must expand our agro-industrial base by establishing processing plants and cold storage facilities right where the land is being restored.

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To make this sustainable, the commission must continue to develop tailored settlement modules. These modules must ensure that land transferred to beneficiaries is utilised productively. This would empower communities to employ local workers and broaden the national economy. According to the estimates of national expenditure, the department plans to complete 99 infrastructure projects over the medium term at an estimated cost of R1,6 billion in the Rural Infrastructure Development sub-programme of the Rural Development Programme.

Planned projects over the period ahead include 15 animal and veldt projects, 9 irrigation schemes, 15 agri-pets and 60 socioeconomic infrastructure that has access to roads and bridges. These are expected to improve quality of life by facilitating ease of doing business and enhancing access to villages and farms, thereby expanding socioeconomic opportunities.

We recognise that a modern economy requires modern fundamentals. The ANC places primacy on the active rollout of basic rural infrastructure by building roads, securing bulk water access and establishing reliable energy connections. These investments ensure mobility, ignite economic

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opportunities and drastically elevate the daily standard of living of our people. Good plans require a sustainable, institutional and funding framework.

In line with the national Development Plan, Medium-Term Development Plan, particularly the focus on inclusive growth, it is critical to expedite the implementation of the District Development Model to co-ordinate public and private capital.

An agrarian transformation cannot succeed in the dark. We have a duty to upscale collaboration with the technology industry and state agencies to aggressively roll out information and communication technology across rural communities. By establishing digital hubs, bringing technology directly into the rural economy, government would be providing sustainable entrepreneurial opportunities.

The primary target must be the youth, ensuring that a young person in a communal property institution has the exact same digital access and economic runaway as a young person in the middle of Sandton.

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Now, I must address the persistent noise that normally continues up there from the opposition benches. They stand before this house in many instances with opportunistic critics, yet they offer absolutely no viable alternative. They indulge in platitude, whilst completely ignoring the immense progress achieved - rural economic stimulus, expanding rural infrastructure projects to generate at least 2 250 direct jobs in vulnerable communities.

Let the record show that as of December 2024, our Land Restitution Programme has successfully settled 83 348 land claims, restoring nearly 3,9 million hectares of land to our people. This progressive transformation has directly benefited over 2,3 million individual beneficiaries across more than 466 000 households. The opposition wants this country to rely strictly on market mechanisms that historically dispossessed the black majority.

The ANC does not rely on empty rhetoric or passive market forces. We implement structured, legally compliant and actively funded interventions to restore home dignity. While the opposition complains, the ANC continues to deliver.

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The birth to an equal prosperous South Africa runs directly through the revitalisation of our rural heartland. By incurring infrastructure on land reform, expanding agro-processing and deploying cutting edge technology, we are securing our food supply, creating jobs and building a developmental state.

In closing, we must be clear, rural development cannot be divorced from the overall development path of this country. There must be no mission drift in terms of rural infrastructure and technological development, as a pathway towards an inclusive and vibrant economic growth trajectory. Rural development is an integral part of the mandate of this department and therefore it cannot be outsourced, underfunded or neglected. On this basis, we must prioritise the processing of the Rural Development Bill to institutionalise economic co-ordination.

On behalf of the ANC, we support this budget as allocated.

Thank you. [Applause.]

Mr A J MNGXITAM: Hon members, we only have one department to deal with the land question, and it is this department. And

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the land question is the beginning of all our troubles. The arrival of Jan van Riebeeck arrived here was the beginning of all our problems. If we look at the department's plans, and its delivery, it is a systematic failure. It is a department which is based on failure. We must remember the 1510 Salt River Battle where the Khoisan defeated the Portuguese. That was the start of the battle for our sovereignty, and of course the colonization project, which is based on the land question. If we do not address the land question, we cannot address racism, we cannot address spatial apartheid, and we cannot address food security. The land question is central, and this is the only department that must deal with this issue, and it is failing systematically. We have a Minister who is an absentee leader. He seems to enjoy more the international conference circuits, where he provides all kinds of glowing representation of the South African land reform programme when it ... [Inaudible.] ... This department is planning to fail. They are planning to deliver 200 000 hectares by 2030. Two hundred thousand hectares in a country where millions and millions of hectares are in the hands of the settler minority. So, there you are. This department is not going to address that matter. It is planning not to address the land question. Similarly with rural development, the Government of National

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Unity, GNU, has abandoned the land question. Let us look at the budget allocation. It is less than 1% of the national budget. What does that mean? We are not serious about addressing the land question. The GNU has abandoned the land question, and landlessness is going to continue. It is unfortunate that the great party of Robert Sobukwe, the PAC, has been tasked to undermine the project of land return. It is a very evil thing that Amavarara [the ANC] has done to put PAC in a position where it must manage the failure to address the land question.

IsiXhosa:

UCyril, udlala ngawe apha. [Kwahlekwa.]

English:

Now, let us look at some of the key failures. The land restitution programme, which of course is based on the false historical event of putting land dispossession to 1913. It will take more than 100 years to be addressed. We are not even talking about the new order claims, which are claims which must still be dealt with, which have been parked in terms of a court order. We are talking about the old order claims, which themselves are not being resolved. In fact, what the

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restitution program does is to give money and land to white farmers, because when there is a land return, white farmers take the money. And then, of course, when there is the situation of our people accepting money instead of land, the white farmer keeps the land. So literally, this programme is about legitimizing land dispossession and buying land for white farmers. So, where are black people here? They are labour tenants. We, as a committee, went out to Mpumalanga and we saw the conditions of labour tenants. They are slaves on those farms. White farmers tricked government in 1996. They proposed a thing called Farm Worker Equity Schemes and our government accepted it. Today, that scheme has given white farmers R700 million. And as soon as the money comes into their farms, they evict these farm workers, who are supposed to be owners. We are dealing with a crisis here and failure of a government that is supposed to look after our people. The same with Communal Property Associations. They are failing and then white farmers come and sometimes they become partners and the boss remain the boss in the farm. But they say that our people have now received the land.

Let us turn to the Ingonyama Trust. Minister, we must just do the right thing. Respect the king, give the powers to the king

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to appoint and dismiss his board at his pleasure, just like the President of the country has the right to appoint and dismiss Ministers at his pleasure. Let us give dignity back to the king. It is not up to us commoners to interfere with the land management system, which is communal and is well established. So ...

IsiXhosa:

... ndiyakucela M-Afrika ukuba uhloniphe iinkosi neekumkani uzinike amandla azo.

English:

There is a solution to this problem, and the MK Party is bringing that solution to Parliament. Look at us, we are all black here, with very few settlers ... [Interjections.] ... We have a majority in this Parliament.

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Hon member, just hold on for a moment.

Mr C F B SMIT: Thank you, House Chair.

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The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Just wait to be recognised first. Hon member, why do you want to be recognised?

Mr C F B SMIT: It is on a point of order. The hon member reflected on members of this House as being settlers and I want you to rule on that. Thank you.

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): I did not hear his name specific members. I will consider the matter, and if it warrants a ruling, I will come back. Hon Mngxitam, please continue. [Applause.]

Mr J A MNGXITAM: We are a black majority. This parliament is a black majority. We can get up to 90% of the vote. So, the MK Party is bringing before you an amendment of section 25, which is about expropriation of land without compensation. This matter will come before us. Now, as black people, we have the choice. To maintain the apartheid racial and land ownership structure or to give land to our people. This is an opportunity that we as black people in this Parliament must not let go. We must grab it, we must use it, and we must bring honour to honourables. We are landless honourables right now. What is honour about a landless Member of Parliament? We are

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landless ourselves, we are representing landless people, but we have the chance to change the situation ... [Applause.] ... Thank you, Chair. We reject this Budget Vote. [Applause.]

Ms L M MASEKO: House Chair, there is a woman in the rural village who wakes up every morning before sunrise to start working. Her name is Dikeledi. Twenty years ago, her family celebrated when government officials arrived at their village and announced that the community's land claim has finally been approved. There were speeches, promises, cameras flashing, and leaders speaking about dignity, empowerment, and the new beginning. The community believed that their lives were about to change. But today, Minister, Dikeledi still walks many kilometres to fetch water because the farm has no functioning infrastructure. The irrigation system promised years ago was never installed. The tractors broke down long ago and were never repaired. The training programme stopped after a few months. The local access road is full of potholes, making it difficult to transport produce to markets. The land is there, but opportunities are not.

Ultimately, Dikeledi's son had to leave for the city because there were no jobs in their village. Her daughter wanted to

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start a small farming business but could not access financial support because she still had to secure the title deed.

Minister, Dikeledi and her family's story is not unique. Too many South Africans face decades-long delays in restitution claims, and countless families grow old waiting for justice. In certain instances, emerging farmers do receive land, yes, but they receive little to no support from the government. This is the story of budget spent without visible outcomes.

The greatest tragedy is that South Africans have lost confidence in the department's ability to implement land reform effectively. We need to understand that land reform remains one of the most important emotional responsibilities of this government. This is not only about hectares transferred. It is about dignity, but most importantly, it is about the responsibility to carry the hopes of millions who were dispossessed, excluded, and denied economic participation for generations. It is about whether a young person in a rural village can find work close to home, whether emerging farmers can feed this nation, and whether families who waited decades for justice can finally receive secure ownership and opportunities.

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Minister, Budget Vote 42 speaks to one of the most important mandates in our democracy. Yet year after year, we continue to see a widening gap between promises made and outcomes delivered. The department speaks of transformation, but too many land reform beneficiaries remain unsupported, underfinanced, and abandoned after transfer. Land without infrastructure, financing, mentorship, water rights, market access, and security of tenure does not create empowerment. It just creates frustration. Millions are spent acquiring land, yet sufficient attention is not given to ensure it becomes productive and sustainable. Too many farms transferred through restitution and redistribution programmes collapse, and beneficiaries are left without post-settlement support. That is not empowerment. It is setting people up for a failure.

Another major concern is underperformance and under expenditure. Communities wait years, sometimes generations, for restitution claims to be finalized, for example, the District Six restitution claims were lodged at the dawn of democracy. Yet after five Presidents and more than seven different Ministers, they are still not finalized. Some claimants have passed away before seeing resolution. That is not merely an administrative backlog. It is a failure to

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urgency. We must also address the issue of insecure tenure rights. Millions of South Africans living on communal lands still lack legally enforceable ownership or long-term security. Women in rural communities remain particularly vulnerable when tenure systems fail to adequately protect them. Without secure tenure, there can be no meaningful economic participation, no collateral finance, and no certainty to future generations. If we are serious about the department's core mandate, then several urgent interventions are required. Firstly, post-settlement support must become the centrepiece of land reform policy. Land reform cannot succeed without partnership between the government, the private sector, agricultural ... [Inaudible.] ... and the commercial farmers.

Secondly, the department must prioritize title deeds and secure tenure rights. Ownership creates confidence, investment and economic participation. South Africans must not remain perpetual tenants of the state.

Thirdly, corruption and wasteful expenditure must be aggressively confronted. Every rand wasted is a betrayal of poor South Africans who depend on the department.

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Fourthly, rural safety must be incorporated into rural development. Farmers, farm workers, and rural residents cannot produce, invest or live with dignity amid rising crime and stock theft, and lastly, the department must modernize its systems. Delays in restitution processing, land audits, beneficiary verification, project approvals continue to undermine delivery. South Africa does not lack land reform policies. What we lack is implementation, accountability, and measurable outcomes. The people of South Africa deserve more than symbolic reform. They deserve real empowerment. They deserve a department that delivers not only land but opportunity, productivity and hope. Thank you. [Applause.]

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Thank you. Hon members, before I recognise the next speaker, I have considered the point of order raised. Now firstly, of course, the two Rules that may come into play here are Rules 84 and 85. Rule 84 dealing with unparliamentary language or gestures, and Rule 85 the reflection upon the integrity of other members. Now firstly, if one considers the term settler, I have quickly consulted the dictionary, and the dictionary says a settler is a person who moves to a new, often previously uninhabited or sparsely populated area with the intention of establishing a

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permanent community or home. That is according to the Cambridge Dictionary. So, the word clearly cannot be unparliamentary. If one considers the context further, it is clear that no specific member was indicated by the hon Mngxitama in making the statement he made and therefore no finding can be made properly that Rule 85 was breached. Having said that, hon Mngxitama, it is of course also so that when we refer to other members of the House in general, we must do so mindful of the fact that all of the members here have sworn an oath of allegiance to the Constitution, a Constitution which proclaims that none of us are lesser members. And I would caution using a language in which the context might show that you are of the view that some members are of less standing than others. Let us continue with the debate. The next speaker ... [Interjections.]

Mr M A NHANHA: Chair, on a point of order.

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Yes, hon Nhanha.

Mr M A NHANHA: I do not contest your ruling, Chair. I fully accept it. But I did keep the clock when hon Maseko was speaking. She used exactly five minutes, and she is now left

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with one minute. Can I be accredited with that one minute?

Thank you, Chair. [Interjections.]

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): That is a point of ... let us say, household, which you can take up with the table staff, but maybe you must just get new batteries for your clock, because on my clock she had 15 seconds left.

Mr N S MATIASE: House Chair, the EFF rises to reject this budget yet again because it does not answer no attempt to resolve the land question. It does not respond to the historical violence of colonial and apartheid land dispossession. It does not carry the agency required by millions of black people who remain landless in the land of their birth. It is a budget of delay, a budget of excuses, a budget that protects the status quo.

This budget reiterates the land reform, and rural development program is neither a priority nor agent, thus showing no respect whatsoever to the landless masses of poor people. It remains underfunded, fragmented, and politically compromised. It proves that this government continues to fall in resolving the historical land question.

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The report before Parliament tells us what we already know. The department total budget decreased from R10,4 billion in 2025/26 financial year to R10,3 billion in 2026/27 financial year. In real terms, this is a 4,3% decline. A department responsible for reversing one of the greatest injustices in our history comes to this House with less money, less agency, and no credibility whatsoever in the path of land reform and land transformation.

This budget funds offices better than funding land reform. Office accommodation alone receives R693,9 million. How do we explain that to the farm dwellers who still face eviction? How do we explain that to labour tenants who have waited for decades for the claims to be settled? How do we explain that to communities whose land claims have moved from one file to another, from one promise to another, from one administration to another?

Rural development programme budget is also being weakened. The department increases funding for National Rural Youth Service Corps, NARYSEC, A rather but reduces rural infrastructure allocation. The target for job creation through rural development initiative dropped from 450 to 300. The number of

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rural infrastructure projects fall to 33, with 63 in 2024/25, and 175 in 2023/24. What kind of rural development creates fewer jobs and builds fewer projects?

Young people in rural areas do not need training that leads to nowhere. They need land, water, road infrastructure, production infrastructure, markets, finance, extension services, and enterprise support. Without these, NARYSEC, risks becoming a numbers programme counting young people trained without providing sustainable employment or ownership.

The Office of the Valuer-General is also operating with serious instability. The Valuer-General post has been vacant since 2019 and the chief operating officer post since 2016. How can we trust the land valuation process when the institution responsible for valuation has been without critical leadership for years? Yet, there are many still crises this budget and reports return with over so many years with old stories repeating the same excuses and lamentations. The EFF maintains that land reform must never be treated as a side issue. A land reform program run on a spreadsheet cannot deliver justice.

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This budget does not represent a credible break with colonial and apartheid land ownership patents. It maintains the status quo while presenting minimal targets as transformation. The land question cannot be postponed. The landlessness cannot be ritualised. The landless cannot eat promises. Rural communities cannot survive on reports with empty promises. We have got to do something.

We had the discussions in the portfolio committee meeting last night which ended badly with the Deputy Minister refusing to take individual responsibility as a former ambassador, as a former premier and currently as a Deputy Minister of Land Reform and Rural Development wanting to cast responsibility on all of us even though that we have not been part of the ruling party. We have not been part of the ruling government.

We call upon you and the Minister to do something. Hon Mngxitama has presented a proposal for which we need to consider. We have got our numbers. We can do the right thing in the interest of the landless. We can do something that at least when we cast our minds back, we can say to Robert Sobukwe, your sacrifice, your time you spent in prison, your

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isolation, your persecution was not in vain. The EFF rejects this budget. Thank you.

Mr M A MNCWANGO: House Chairperson, Minister and Deputy Minister, hon members, the IFP notes the tabling of budget Vote 42 as a true test of whether national policies will alter the lived experiences and realities of rural communities or merely become compliance exercises.

We welcome the allocation as a vital fiscal mechanism to execute our constitutional imperatives. It provides the means to promote holistic rural development and restore dignity to our communities. Addressing historical inequalities in land access remains a foundational pillar for building an inclusive and modernised agrarian economy.

Our focus must look to the opportunities embedded within the allocation. We commend initiatives to modernise land administration system, particularly the phased implementation of the electronic deeds registration system, which will improve turnaround times and secure land tenure rights.

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The rollout of the National Rural Youth Service Corps also remains an admirable vehicle for rural youth skills development. Yet the pace of land reform is almost slower than communities have actually hoped for, creating frustration among those who have actually waited decades for justice. To accelerate this mandate, land must be treated as a clear national priority.

However, this portfolio faces declining fiscal support with funds increasingly directed away from the department's core mandate, that is land redistribution, restitution, and tenure reform. The current land acquisition budget is less than 0,5% of the national budget, yet land reform is a constitutional priority. The highest level was in 2006/07, when the budget was 1,09% of the national budget.

Purchasing land is costly, and the budget remains limited to cover both acquisition and post-settlement support. This dual burden strains implementation capacity and highlights the need for new funding approaches and stronger inter-departmental collaboration. Our institutional capacity remains limited. As we enter the third year of this administration, vital public entities still lack permanent leadership.

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The Office of the Valuer-General is a clear example, where key executive positions remain vacant, resulting in a lack of stable leadership continuity and credibility in valuations, which in turn delays land delivery. Urgently filling these vacancies will restore confidence and strengthen delivery.

Furthermore, resolving funding and leadership constraints will unlock the land reform value chain. Correcting fiscal priorities and restoring the land acquisition baseline will provide capital to scale redistribution. Stabilising executive leadership and appointing a permanent Valuer-General will eliminate valuation backlogs. A simple and well-resourced foundation will accelerate land delivery, clear historical backlogs, and reduce frustrations. Moving forward, the primary objective ... The IFP, therefore, supports budget Vote 42.

[Time expired.]

Mr S H M VAN WYK: Hon House Chairperson, greetings to all the hon members in the House. Greetings to the hon Minister of Department of Rural Development and Land Reform and our Deputy Minister. I rise on behalf of the PA on Budget Vote 42. We speak today for the forgotten, the landless and the excluded. Let us be clear, the injustice of land dispossession did not

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end with apartheid. It continues today not in the form of forced removals of the past but in the form of delayed justice, broken promises and systemic exclusion from land restitution processes. Up until this day, families who lost their land under the Natives Land Act and subsequent apartheid laws have received neither their land back nor fair compensation.

The Restitution Act promised closure but instead, we have bureaucratic paralysis. The state admits many large claims remained unsettled but how many more decades must victims wait. Worse, where the land reform is happening corruption has taken root. We have witnessed tenders awarded to political connected middlemen while genuine beneficiaries are sidelined. The Steinkopf title deed process is a textbook example of political interference gone wrong. Instead of following lawful procedures, political meddling delayed and distorted transfer of land to rightful owners. This is not reform. This is exclusion of the vulnerable.

Then, there is a matter of small-scale farmer's support. Budgets have been allocated, programmes have been announced yet coloured small-scale farmers especially in the Free State

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are not being assisted, like Wayne Fischer, Charl Adams, Zayne Jordaan, Lizelle Kraalsoek and her colleagues, Thabo Mahlobo and many others. The PA will not accept these excuses. We will keep the pressure on the department until every person, black, white, coloured and Indian who was wronged by land laws is treated fairly until corruption is rooted out and until political interference in land deals is a thing of the past.

Furthermore, it is imperative that we tackle the matter of problematic Communal Property Associations, CPAs, many of whom are embroiled in corruption allegations and face community complaints, such as those in Platfontein, Oppermansgronde, Saron, Richtersveld and numerous other areas across South Africa. As a department, it is incumbent upon you to address these CPAs. We demand you to finalise outstanding restitution claims, prosecute corrupt officials and ensure equal access to farmer support programmes. The land belongs to those who work on it and those from whom it was stolen from. I thank you. We support the vote.

Dr W J BOSHOFF: House Chair, hon Minister, Deputy Minister and colleagues, there is an Afrikaans expression which I have used in this debate at previous times and it is ...

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Afrikaans:

... die grondvraag is die grondvraag.

English:

... meaning the land question is the basic question. Now, this is the essence of politics in South Africa today and we are trying to sidestep it. We are trying to work around it in some way. We are trying to get a bureaucratic or pragmatic way around the central political question in South Africa, which is the ownership of land and the recognition of the peoples who live within South Africa.

Now there are several technical questions we can ask about this department. I wrote a few down. How much land is in black hands? We do not really know. How much land is in state hands? We do not really know. Is there some way to compare the size of land in the Karoo and in the Mpumalanga lowveld? Like, do we have small stock units or large stock units and not hectares? A hectare is not equal to a unit in terms of economy. How successful are land projects? Are Communal Property Associations, CPAs effective vehicles for communities? How effective are the entities within the department? Is the budget sufficient? Do we believe in a

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central planning economy or a market economy? Are private deeds the final solution to everything?

I just wanted to say something about title deeds and that it is so economically useful not because it gives you the right to own the land, it also gives you the right to lose the land. You can lose the land if the bank can take it as a security. That is the essence of why banks regard private property as bankable and not communal property. Communal property cannot be lost.

You see, what we come to is that there are two fundamentally different ways which are not exclusively in relation to each other but they complement each other and are radically different. The one, is land is an economic commodity. Land is something you use to make money on or to create subsistence for yourself. The other is that land and identity are intertwined with each other. It is basically the same. You cannot be a person, a people or a group without land associated to you.

Now, what happened in 1994 is that the old power elite said:

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Let us give you the political power if we can keep all the property that we used to have.

And the new power elite said:

Let us concede a little bit on land and on the property if we can get the political power because if we have the political power, in time we can have all the rest too.

Now the problem is that, that solution of 1994 had never been a permanent one. From the beginning, it had been a settlement, a compromise which was the point of the greatest mutual dissatisfaction. We must settle this. We must talk to each other and the essence of that would be the recognition of Afrikaners and other minorities as permanent and not settlers. I thank you.

Mr R A P TROLLIP: Hon Chairperson, land reform remains one of South Africa's most important constitutional and economic responsibilities. Rural development cannot succeed where land reform is slow, corrupt, poorly administered, unsupported or disconnected from economic opportunity. The budget cut from R4,6 billion to R3,9 billion is a red flag. This department

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cannot perform optimally in isolation from the Department of Agriculture. It is conjoined but it has been separated and we understand why. They had to create some extra posts in the Government of National Unity.

IsiXhosa:

Mphathiswa, mna anduzukufundela le ngxelo njengabanye abantu. Ndiyathemba ukuba niyifundile namagosa akho. Siyi-Action SA siyayixhasa le ngxelo kodwa ningenzi ngolu hlobo kwenzeka ngalo. Sithi makulungiswe iindlela zenu nenze ngohlobo olufanelekileyo.

English:

Action SA supports meaningful land reform that is lawful, transparent, economically sustainable and focused on empowerment rather than political patronage and output versus outcomes-based initiatives.

IsiXhosa:

Umhlaba wodwa ayisosiqalo nasiphelo (Alpha noOmega). Baninzi abantu abanikwe umhlaba ngurhulumente kodwa balambile. Bancame bathengisa ucingo, amazinki, iimpompo, imibhobho yokunkcenkceshela nazo zonke izixhobo zokusebenza ngomhlaba.

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Baphinda kwabona bathi abanazo izixhobo zokusebenza. Izinto ezinjalo zenza ukuba kuphele kwanto kwezi ndawo bahlala kuzo bashiyeke abantu belamba.

Nazi ke izinto ezintathu ezidinga ingqwalasela yakho Mphathiswa nesebe lakho.

English:

Firstly, massive failure in post-settlement support.

Government often transfers land without ensuring beneficiaries can actually farm productively. Many emerging farmers lack access to finance, equipment, water, infrastructure, market access, training and extension services. Productive farms collapse because the state abandons beneficiaries after transfer. This is where the partnership with the Department of Agriculture is so important.

IsiXhosa:

Mphathiswa, phaya ngakuthi ekhaya, kukho iifama ezininzi ezithengwe ngurhulumente. IMalanskraal yenye yeefama ezathengwa ngurhulumente.

English:

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Malanskraal was the most expensive farm sold in Bedford.

IsiXhosa:

Akuqhubeki kwanto ngoku kula fama. Lihlazo lodwa eliphaya kula fama. Kwinyanga ephelileyo bendigqitha ngakula fama ndabona esangweni kubhalwe ukuba bathengisa iinkuni. Aba bantu baphelele ekuthengiseni iinkuni zomnga. Ayikho enye into abanokuyivelisa ukuze bayithengise benze inzuzo. Hayi lihlazo lodwa oluya.

English:

Secondly, dysfunctional state-owned land management. Large amounts of state-owned land remain unused or underutilised. Thousands of beneficiaries still do not have title deeds or secure tenure. Bureaucratic delays trap people in uncertainty and prevent investment.

IsiXhosa:

Ingathi urhulumente wethu ukholwa kukuba abantu baxhomekeke kuye ukuze akwazi ukubalawula ngendlala bahlale bengamakhoboka. Amafama eeorenji eNkonkobe awakabinazo iziqinisekisi zobumnini (title deeds) ukusukela ngel1990 ukuza

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kuthi ga namhlanje. Niwaqamangele izandla neenyawo la mafama alima iio renji.

English:

Thirdly, corruption and cadre deployment land reform projects have repeatedly been undermined by corruption.

IsiXhosa:

Izixhobo zokuvelisa ukutya emhlabeni nesivuno azityiwa zimpuku koko zityiwa ngabantu abanyolikileyo. Kutheni le nto kunje? Hayi, masingathandabuzi ntonje masijonge esipilini sixele ukuba sibona ntoni na. Mandinixelele ukuba ndibona ntoni mna. Mna ndibona iiprojekhthi zivuswa kodwa amantshontsho ehagu ayatyiwa. Xa begqiba ukutya amantshontsho, bachitha iihoko bathengise naloo maplanga bekwakhiwe ngawo iihoko. Emva koko baye bakhale ngendlala.

Omnye obelapha, uMgaga ohloniphekileyo, umkile ngoku. Ebesithi konke kuhamba kakuhle kwaye zonke izinto ziyaqhubeka kodwa abantu babaleka indlala ezindaweni zabo baye kwizixeko ezikhulu. [Kwaphela ixesha.]

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The DEPUTY MINISTER OF LAND REFORM AND RURAL DEVELOPMENT: Hon Chairperson, hon Minister Nyhontso, hon members; Minister Nyhontso has addressed land reform and land administration which are directly linked to rural development. My input will therefore focus on rural development in line with my delegations. While rural development is a concurrent function, our department has a clear leadership responsibility. This includes developing overall strategic direction and providing policy coherence, co-ordination and implementation support, whilst also being directly involved in implementation through our department's rural development programmes.

Our responsibility matters because rural underdevelopment in South Africa was not accidental. Its foundations were laid systematically through colonisation apartheid or what you could call colonisation of a special term. The racial exclusion and discrimination that underpinned were further produced by both sustained racialised rural underdevelopment. It is precisely because of the stubborn legacy of rural underdevelopment that South Africa needs coherent rural development pursuit as a national priority.

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A prosperous South Africa cannot be secured while millions of our people in rural areas have not fully realised the elimination of the centuries' old rural underdevelopment. Rural development is therefore not only about improving conditions in villages and in small towns, it is about correcting historical injustice and systematically eliminating and even development to level the playing field. It is about ensuring that where a person is born does not determine the limits of their future. Therefore, our department continues to implement the Integrated Rural Development Sector Strategy. This strategy provides a coherent or a comprehensive and multi sectoral framework for transforming rural communities. It recognises that rural development cannot be achieved through isolated interventions. The strategy requires co-ordinated action across government, across sectors and with communities themselves at the centre.

Work has also begun on a National Rural Development Policy and Rural Development Bill. These instruments are intended to strengthen the long term legislative and policy foundation for rural transformation. The work was significantly advanced during the National Rural Development Indaba held in Mangaung earlier this month. This confirmed a broad national consensus

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- rural development must move higher on the country's development agenda.

Over the medium term, the Rural Development Programme is allocated R2 658 502 000 million. This allocation represents 8,3% of the department's total budget. In the 2026-27 financial year the Rural Development Programme receives R723 383 000 million. This allocation will support rural infrastructure projects, rural youth skills development initiatives linked to work opportunities, Rural Technology Research and Development and Rural Development Co-ordination. So our development will be targeted.

In the 2026-27 financial year, the Rural Infrastructure Development programme is allocated R378 179 000 million. In 2027-28, the allocation for Rural Infrastructure Development sub-programme rises to R596 658 000 million. In 2028-29 it rises to R622 529 000 million. Over the medium term, the department has therefore planned to complete rural infrastructure projects with an estimated value of approximately R1,6 billion to improve economic and social development conditions in rural communities. This will cover

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infrastructure such as roads, bridges, irrigation systems, digital access, and community facilities.

The Rural Infrastructure Developments sub-programme is expected to contribute to economic and social development in rural areas, among others, through co-operatives and small, medium micro enterprise targeting and in line with the District Development Model. This is also part of rural industrialization as a rural development imperative to transform rural areas from mere sites of extraction and primary protection to centres of high value addition.

In the 2026-27 financial year, the National Rural Youth Service Corps, NARYSEC, sub-programme is allocated R291 514 000. This allocation will support the skills development of rural youth, including 1227 young people, linking them to employment or small enterprise development opportunities.

In 2026-27 financial year, the Technology Research and Development sub-programme received R33 50 000 million. And this allocation will include five rural schools in the department's Rural Technology Research and Development

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partnership with the Department of Basic Education and Council for Scientific and Industrial Research, CSIR. In the same financial year, Rural Development Co-ordination is allocated R20 640 000 million.

Hon members, the challenge before us is clear. We must move from fragmented rural intervention to integrated rural transformation. We must move from rural poverty to rural productivity. We must move from inherited inequality to shared prosperity. The department accepts this responsibility. The resolutions of the Rural Development Indaba are being translated now into programme of action that will be implemented by the government in partnership with multi sectoral stakeholders and communities.

We will continue to build rural development leadership to co-ordinate and to drive implementation in line with our constitutional and developmental mandate. When rural communities thrive, South Africa thrives. When rural families prosper, national prosperity advances. When the country is transformed, the democratic promise of freedom becomes more real for all. And indeed, the people shall share in this country's wealth. I thank you.

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Mr W M THRING: Hon House Chairperson, in welcoming the opportunity to engage on this Budget Vote, the ACDP notes some R9,6 billion allocation to the Department of Land Reform and Rural Development for the 2026-27 financial year. While this figure appears substantial, the portfolio committee's May 2026 report reveals that core land reform and restitution budgets have been cut, undermining the very mandate of this department.

Recent revelations from the Special Investigating Unit, SIU, are deeply troubling. It has found that some R650 million in irregular matters, with 68 officials facing disciplinary action and 611 cases referred to the National Prosecuting Authority. These scandals erode public trust and weaken the financial health of our economy as funds meant for justice and restitution are diverted through corruption and maladministration.

The committee further highlighted 8 000 unresolved labour tenant cases and persistent capacity failures, vacancies, acting posts and delayed systems. These failures mean that land redistribution targets remain far below the national goals, perpetuating inequality and slowing rural economic

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growth. The ACDP has consistently argued that land reform must be just, transparent and economically sustainable. Without strong oversight and efficient delivery, rural communities remain trapped in poverty and our broader economy suffers from instability in land ownership and agricultural productivity.

The ACDP, as kingdom builders, calls for some urgent corrective measures. Firstly, stronger funding for restitution. Secondly, tighter oversight of departmental spending. Thirdly, swift appointments to fill critical vacancies. We position that only then can land reform serve both justice and economic health. Thank you, hon Chair.

Xitsonga:

Tat S M GANA: Mutshamaxitulu na Holobye ...

IsiZulu:

... bazobuya nayo abafana e-Mbombela ngoMgqibelo.

English:

... once and always.

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Minister, South Africa, as we know, does not have a land shortage problem. What we do have is an urban residential land problem. That is where the real pressure sits. The greatest demand for land today in South Africa is in our cities and towns where millions of South Africans are searching for land for residential purposes, for dignity and for a place to call home. Until we confront that honestly, we will continue to misunderstand the frustration around the pace of land reform, redistribution and restitution. When people cannot access land closer to economic opportunity, transport, schools and work, anger grows. The land question is no longer about ownership. It is about access, development and opportunity.

At the same time, there remains a serious challenge around agricultural land in rural South Africa. The painful truth is that there is still a significant amount of arable land that is either underutilised or not used productively at all. Some of that land, as you know, came through the redistribution and restitution processes yet communities still do not feel empowered as true economic participants. Land reform cannot end with a title deed ceremony or opportunity. Land reform must create productive farmers, sustainable rural economies and thriving communities. Land alone is just not enough. When

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land does not have roads, it is in isolation. Land without the markets produces poverty and land without infrastructure is an abandonment. We can agree, Minister, that land without water is not very useful.

If this budget is to mean anything to the people in our villages and farming communities, then the rural infrastructure development funding must prioritise key infrastructure, especially water infrastructure, because once water arrives, development follows. People can farm, small businesses can emerge and livestock can survive. Food security can also improve. Water is the foundation upon which rural economic development stands. I come from a village, Lefara. I have seen how decisions taken over many years collapse local agricultural activity, especially through the neglect of the water systems and the rural infrastructure. We know we cannot change yesterday, but we can decide what we do today.

We must use this budget to change the narrative around this department. Rural development cannot remain an afterthought while urban centres continue to absorb people fleeing underdevelopment in rural areas.

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Xitsonga:

Ndza khensa swinene, Mutshamaxitulu.

English:

Saturday, ...

IsiZulu:

... hhayi ... [Akuzwakali.] ...

The DEPUTY MINISTER OF SOCIAL DEVELOPMENT: Hon Chair...

IsiZulu:

... sanibonani ...

English:

Al Jama-ah supports this budget although this department continues to fail farm dwellers and labour tenants. There are one million of them that are soon to be evicted. Just in one court in Paarl there are nearly 500 cases by farmers who wants to evict labour tenants.

We cannot ignore the calls for expropriation without compensation - we cannot ignore it. Al Jama-ah is concerned

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about the evictions. I said a million labour tenants are soon to be evicted. We have a different approach. House Chair, you know that farm dwellers live on a small portion of a very big farm. In thousands of hectares, they may live just on 1 000 or 2 000 square meters.

What is Al Jama-ah's approach? All over the country, and a practical example is the Nantes farm in Paarl. That portion of land that the farm dwellers are working on must be expropriated without compensation. We feel that that is a good start. It is not going to harm the farmers because they own thousands of hectares of land, and here we are only asking for, let us say, 1 000 square meters or 2 000 square meters where people have lived on this land which is an ancestral land.

One of the other concerns that we have is that labour laws are used to evict farm dwellers and labour tenants. The department must ensure the due legal protection and security of the tenure of labour tenants with ancestral linkages to the land, as well as those with long periods of service on the land along with their families. As the law stands, a material breach of a labour contract between the labour tenant and the

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farmer will entitle the farmer to cancel the contract, and the labour tenant will lose his right to live in his home on the farm immediately. In terms of the present legislation, when a farmer sells a farming business, they only have to keep them for a year, and after that put new conditions of employment.

Retrenchment positions have been slipped in to allow them to be evicted. The department needs to look at the labour laws which harm labour tenants. Thank you very much.

Dr L W MAHLATSI: Thank you, Chairperson.

Sesotho:

Kgotso, Maafrica!

English:

The report on Budget Vote 42 under the Land Reform and Rural Development admits institutional instability, under capacitation, high vacancy rates, weak monitoring system and poor coordination. Yet, we are presented with an ambitious of 200 000 hectares rural infrastructure, youth training, digitisation and modern land administration. However, here is a contradiction: Programme 3, Land Reform and Restitution, the

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core of land justice, is cut by R375 million in real terms, while administration and planning budget increases.

Money is moving away from Land Reform while paperwork increase. This incapacity does not occur in vacuum. It is enabled by the Portfolio Committee on Land Reform that failed to exercise consequences management and oversight. Instead of holding officials and executives accountable, it becomes the spectators while the Land Reform is sabotaged through these budgets that do not even translate into deliveries.

The SIU has already pointed to officials implicated in undermining the land reform. The committee report confirmed the same symptoms: Weak system; delays; poor data; litigation backlogs; and departments that cannot translate plan into delivery. Our people are hungry.

Sesotho:

Batho ba rona ba lapile ...

English:

... and the land remains one of the most powerful tools for their survival and dignity. The department must therefore

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ensure that the people are not only given land but are enabled to use it productively so that they can feed themselves, sustain their households and take full control of their food production system.

When the UAT speak of the land, we refer not only to the agricultural land alone but to the full spectrum of natural wealth. These include our minerals beneath our soil, our mountains and our rivers above it. Our people must derive tangible benefit from all these resources as part of comprehensive and inclusive model, economic justice and share prosperity. The UAT rejects Budget Vote 42. [Applause.]

Xitsonga:

Khanimamba!

Mr M A NHANHA: It looks like the progressive caucus is regrouping. Hon Chairperson, Minister, Deputy Minister, hon members and everybody else in the House, I am about to deliver an indictment on a democratic state. It is the year 1886: A sprawling racially integrated and cosmopolitan settlement has just been established on the West Bank of the Buffalo River near East London city centre, known today as Kugompo City.

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Soon after this establishment, Kwanongqongqo, the West Bank village, it grew into a strong, vibrant, peaceful and multicultural society. Then, the Nationalist Party won elections in 1948, and it introduced the ideology of separate development, more commonly known as apartheid. In 1958, the Minister of Native Affairs, Dr H F Verwoed, decided to break up this well-established community and forcibly removed them to make way for an industrial area where the city's Mercedes-Benz factory was ultimately built.

A new dormitory township was subsequently built some 30 kilometres from East London, to be developed in a Bantu homeland of Ciskei. This made it possible to relocate all African families living in East London, including those who were living in the West Bank village. In 1965, approximately 7 000 families were relocated from Kwanongqongqo under the Bantu Administration Act of 1945 and the Group Areas Act of 1950.

African families were moved to Mdantsane, whilst coloured families were moved to Buffalo Flats. Harrowing stories are told by those who lived to tell the tale. "We won't forget that day. It was terrible. We cried whilst our houses were

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pulled down." One displaced person said. "I have great fears about the place I have been forced to go to, and people fear the move to Mdantsane." Another displaced person recalled.

From a functioning township and community with schools, churches and community structures, they were removed to Mdantsane, a place lacking social infrastructure, unfriendly, dark and marked by great economic hardships, with work opportunities very far away. However, with the advent of a democratic dispensation in 1994, a new sense of hope emerged among the displaced families of Kwanongqongqo that their dignity would finally be restored.

Following the approval of the Restitution of Land Rights Act of 1994, the Nongqongqo Committee submitted a land claim in 1998 for their land. The committee unanimously voted for the land-based compensation choosing to rebuild their community near West Bank in East London rather than monetary compensation.

At the signing of the settlement agreement with the government on 16 April 2000, the chairperson of Kwanongqongqo Committee, Mr Ben Ntamo, underscored the sense of their hope. "With the

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community united behind this desire and with the support of the city council, the prospects now look good for a positive outcome."

However, that joy, hope and trust in the new government once resulted in total despair, as it was in 1965. Now, 26 years later, all they have is land: Which is still not provided with services; most of it taken over by land invaders; and they have no hope of ever getting compensation for what they were promised. Their dream of rebuilding a community is currently shuttered. Minister, ... [Interjections.]

The CHAIRPERSON (Mr M G Mahlaule): Hon Nhanha, my apologies. Can you please take a seat? What is that, hon Mahlatsi?

Dr L W MAHLATSI: Hon Chairperson, I just want to check if the honourable member can take a question?

The CHAIRPERSON (Mr M G Mahlaule): Hon Nhanha, are you prepared to take a question?

Mr M A NHANHA: You see, smaller parties, Chairperson, get three minutes.

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The CHAIRPERSON (Mr M G Mahlaule): Are you willing to take a question? Thank you. He is not willing to take a question. Can you proceed?

Mr M A NHANHA: Smaller parties have three minutes, so he is trying to make use of my time. Gaba, it is disheartening ...

IsiXhosa:

... mntakwethu ...

English:

... to note that natural attrition is taking its toll on the first-generation claimants of Kwanongqongqo, who have never realised their dream of living in West Bank in a community as they knew it.

Hon members, the claimants of Kwanongqongqo are watching today's proceedings on TV across the country. The claimants have knocked on so many doors, Minister after Minister, mayor after mayor in Buffalo City, with limited or no success at all. They have now resorted to us in Parliament as their last hope. We dare not fail them. The claimants can be assured that the DA will not rest, retreat or relent until the

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Kwanongqongqo Settlement Agreement is fully, fairly and completely implemented.

Hon Chairperson, I wish to thank Durban City for silencing Pirates last week and I know Orbit will do the same and I want to thank them in advance. Thank you very much. [Applause.]

Ms N A NDALANE: Chairperson, hon Minister and Deputy Minister, hon chairperson of the portfolio committee, hon members, let me start with the opposition, the way they were adopting the budget. There is nothing we can do with people who come up with good ideas, but at the same time, reject the report. They reject the Budget Vote, and they reject everything. At the end of the day, the ANC ...

Xitsonga:

... ya wu hundzisa mpimanyeto lowu naswona hi ta humelela.

English:

I stand before this august House to deliver an address on the fundamental pillar of our democratic transformation, land reform. We are at a critical juncture in our nation's history, where the unresolved question of land remains a visible scar

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on our socioeconomic landscape. It acts as the anchor for inclusive economic growth and the cornerstone of national reconciliation. We cannot achieve true freedom when the primary asset of production remains skewed by a colonial and apartheid dispossession. Our historical mandate requires us to expedite land redistribution and restitution. At the same time, we must ensure that the productive use of acquired land for commercial viability is secured to secure food production and stimulate rural economies.

To build a capable, ethical and developmental state that our citizens demand, the ANC-led Government of National Unity, GNU, must aggressively pursue the key strategic delivery objectives, which include 200 hectares of land for equitable access and secure tenure option, rural economic stimulus, and expanding rural infrastructure projects to generate at least 2 250 direct jobs within vulnerable communities. To realise these objectives, the department must expedite the passage of progressive legislation, particularly the Equitable Access to Land Bill, to formalise a just redistribution framework.

Furthermore, the government must intensify and capitalise on its Post-Settlement Land Development Support Programme.

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Through this land development support programme, the state provides co-ordinated technical, infrastructural, and market facilitation support. This guarantees that land remains highly productive immediately following its transfer. True land justice requires that we secure the tenure of those who live and work on the land. We must immediately improve and strengthen Farmworker Equity Schemes to deliver life-changing benefit to farm labourers and reshape historical production relations in a meaningful way. The department must move with speed on claims and protect rural dwellers against illegal eviction. This will be achieved by fully executing the Special Master on Labour Tenants Implementation Plan for the definitive settlement of outstanding applications.

It is critically important to restore stable governance and strict financial accountability within the Ingonyama Trust Board and all related entities to protect the rights of traditional communities. To those who claim that land reform threatens economic stability, the ANC record of delivery offers definitive evidence to the contrary. To date, the democratic state has acquired over 9,2 million hectares of productive land across the length and breadth of our country. Successful projects are proving that equitable redress and

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economic growth can coexist seamlessly. These projects include the ecotourist model Somkhanda Game Reserve, reclaimed by the Gumbi community under the Restitution of Land Rights Act 22 of 1994. This project showcases how conservation can drive local economies. By dedicating the majority of the restored land and biodiversity, the community established a Big Five reserve that attracts global tourists and sustains hundreds of community-led jobs. The agricultural training model Ga Mawela and the Bela Bela Communal Property Associations, CPAs, manage over 5 000 hectares of livestock and ecotourism property. These CPAs demonstrate the power of post-settlement support. Through financial management, coaching, and structured agricultural extension, these beneficiaries are actively running commercial operations and a 10-chalet bush lodge.

The strategic joint venture model, Matsamo CPA, based at the Bernard Shabangu Farm, this initiative utilises a high-impact joint venture climate, partnered with technical expertise in certain commercial export networks. The project protects national food security while delivering reliable monthly dividends to households and funding local educational initiatives. Land reform is not a choice between justice and economic stability. It is the unified path to achieve both by

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retaining the land and providing comprehensive support. We safeguard our food security, create employment, and restore human dignity. A primary constraint to the pace of our land reform programme has always been fiscal availability. We cannot rely solely on the constrained national Budget to finance the massive scale of acquisition and post-settlement support that our people require. We must look at innovative, sustainable financial models. To this end, we must urgently open a serious nationwide consideration for the implementation of the targeted agricultural land taxation system. A progressive land tax will serve a dual strategic purpose; Firstly, it serves to discourage land speculation. It penalises owners who either cultivate the land or release it to the market. Secondly, the revenue generated directly from the agricultural tax must be reinvested to fund land acquisition, infrastructure development, and comprehensive technical support for emerging farmers.

By utilising fiscal policy instruments like land taxation, we ensure that agricultural property contributes directly to our own transformation, driving both equity and productivity without draining the central fiscus. As I conclude, let us fulfil the constitutional promise to build a true non-racial,

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just and ... [Inaudible.] ... On behalf of the ANC, we support. [Applause.]

The CHAIRPERSON (Mr M G Mahlaule): Hon members, I'm informed that the Deputy Minister left one minute and 42 seconds, and, therefore, the Minister will have five minutes and 42 seconds.

The MINISTER OF LAND REFORM AND RURAL DEVELOPMENT: Hon Chairperson ...

IsiXhosa:

... masendiqala ngawe Mngxitam ohloniphekileyo xa ubusithi uMongameli alahlekise njee i-PAC ngokuyinika eli sebe.

English:

You see, the difference between President Ramaphosa and your president, former President Zuma, is that President Ramaphosa gave this department to PAC when your president in 2009 gave it to Freedom Front Plus.

IsiXhosa:

Namhlanje uthi abantu beFreedom Fron Plus "ngama-settler".

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English:

That is the problem with you. Allow me first to thank hon members for their contributions to this debate. The debate reflects that despite our differences, there is a broad argument across this House that the land question remains central to the future of South Africa and that rural development cannot be postponed any further.

Hon Mgaga, we appreciate your support for this budget vote and your emphasis on rural infrastructure, post-settlement support, and rural industrialisation. Those matters remain central to our programme of action. Hon Mngxitam, I hear your concern on the pace of land reform. We share the view that more must be done. The challenge before all of us is how we strengthen the programme further because rejecting this budget vote alone will not place one additional hectare in the hands of our people. What will assist is stronger capacity, better systems and more support for the land reform programme itself.

Hon Maseko and hon Nhanha, your concerns regarding restitution, post-settlement support and implementation are noted. Restitution cannot end with land on paper. It must result in serviced land, secure tenure, infrastructure support

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and real community restoration. We accept that land reform cannot succeed if beneficiaries are left without infrastructure, water access, production support, markets and practical support.

IsiXhosa:

Kodwa Jola, kufuneka uwazi umahluko phakathi kohlahlomali lomhlaba neDurban City. [Kwahlekwa.]

English:

Hon Matiase, the figures before this House show clearly that the greater share of the budget supports direct service delivery. More than 80% of this budget supports implementation programmes. Approximately 63% supports land reform programmes with further allocation for rural development and land administration which remain foundational to implementation and delivery.

Hon Mngcwango, we welcome the IFP's support for this budget vote and reaffirm your point regarding National Rural Youth Service Corps, Narysec. This programme remains one of the department's important instruments for rural youth development, combining leadership, practical skills and

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pathways into work or enterprise. We are also moving to fill critical posts that affect delivery capability.

Hon Van Wyk ...

Afrikaans:

... ma se kind.

English:

You know we handed over land in Richtersveld. We are going to resolve the problem of that Communal Property Association, CPA. If they are not complying, we are going to dissolve them. So, the title deeds and CPA stability are important. Through the Transformation of Certain Rural Areas Act, the state land continues to move into community control while the department continues strengthening CPA governance, compliance and sustainability.

Hon Boshoff, in your absence, you want to know how much land is in black hands and state land. You forgot to tell us how much land is in white hands. How did they get that land? What happened to those people who were in that land when that land was usurped from them? Hon Thring, corruption, weak oversight

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and critical vacancies undermine public confidence in land reform. The department is therefore strengthening consequence management, oversight system and institutional capacity so that delivery improves and public trust is restored.

Hon Mahlatsi, we may differ on certain matters but the people of South Africa expect all of us to contribute towards strengthening implementation and improving outcomes. Land reform cannot succeed through permanent disagreement alone. It must also be supported by practical solutions capable institutions and accountable governance. Hon Gana, my Chief Whip, your contribution correctly reminds this House that the land question is not only rural. Urban land hunger remains one of the major realities. Hon Hendricks, we note your concerns. We will resolve the Nantes Estate Farm issue. We were there.

Hon Torllip ...

IsiXhosa:

... siza kuhamba sobabini xa sisiya eBedford ukuya kukhupha iziqinisekisi zobunini. Sesiqalisile kwela phondo laseFree State naseBedford siza kuzisa sitsho sibone nala fama

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ubuthetha ngayo. Iza kupheza ukuthengisa iinkuni itsho ivelise ukutya.

English:

House Chairperson, despite the challenges raised in this debate, the budget vote reflects a department that continued to work under difficult conditions to advance land reform, restitution, and rural development. Hone Chair

IsiXhosa:

... apha endlini simeme Izwi Labantu Forum NPC kunye neAfrican Farmers Association of South Africa, Afasa, nawo onke lamafama ebekhalazela iziqinisekisi zobunini ukuza kungqina ukuba ngenene siqalisile ukuzikhupha. Enyanisweni, le nto yomhlaba naniyive ngathi nina bahleli kweli cala, singumbutho wePAC. Naningapha kweli cala, kumbutho we-ANC nathi ngenxa yokubona ukuba izikere zilingene abachebi nawela ukuza kukhonkotha ngapha. [Kwaphela ixesha.]

Debate concluded.

The mini-plenary session rose at 18:37.